

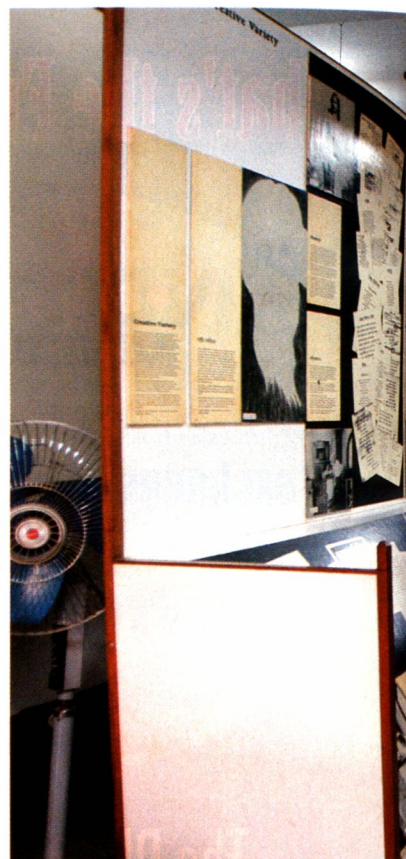
■ By Elora Sen in Shantiniketan

Rabindranath Tagore's Shantiniketan, the abode of peace, is anything but. Four years after the Nobel medallion, awarded to the poet in 1913 went missing, there is still no clue about who committed the crime. Since then other unpleasant facts about this quiet university town that was meant to represent the ideal community have emerged. Priceless pieces of art have disappeared from here with frightening regularity. A recent Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report reveals that over the past few years 900 art objects, including Tagore paintings, have gone missing from the university facilities and more often than not poor security has been the cause. That someone could walk away with the Nobel medal-

forward Tagore's ideals. They call themselves Ashramiks (belonging to the ashram) or Bhumi Putra (son of the soil) and claim that "outsiders", who don't really understand the ethos of Shantiniketan and don't care about its century-old heritage are running the show. Debi Prasanna Chattopadhyaya, former superintendent of maintenance, of Uttarayan and garden department of Rabindra Bhavan, Visva Bharati, is an outspoken critic of what he calls "the outside influence". Rumours are rife that almost all theft from the university premises, which includes sculptures and murals by Tagore, Nandalal Bose, Ramkinkar Baij, Benode Behari Mukherjee, has taken place with inside assistance. "I find it difficult to believe otherwise," says Chattopadhyaya, indignant that he was not consulted during the investiga-

THE ABODE OF NEGLECT

Tagore's dream is slowly disintegrating as apathy and rivalry lead to the loss of peace and many priceless artefacts



lion on March 24, 2004, a Wednesday when the university is closed, underscores the sorry state of affairs. Even today, officials admit, there is no proper catalogue of the 1,500-odd paintings by Tagore that are housed in the Rabindra Bhavan museum.

There is a sense of resentment among those who claim to be carrying

NO HISTORY: The library with Tagore's rare books is being renovated

tions that followed the Nobel theft. He believes people like him, who had served the university for years, should have been allowed to play a more active role in improving the situation. Chattopadhyaya points a finger at former vice-chancellor Sujit Bose during

whose regime the theft occurred.

The issue has now reached the corridors of power in Delhi where the Culture Ministry and the Human Resource Development Ministry (HRD) are in a tussle over the control of the university. The museum, an integral part of Visva Bharati, is under the HRD Ministry as the university itself is deemed as a Central university, controlled by the University Grants Commission (UGC) and getting grants from it. But with articles of such huge value at stake, even the university wants the Culture Ministry to take over. Both Nilanjan Banerjee, special officer, Visva Bharati and Amitava Choudhury, public relation officer, say that the university has made an appeal for the museum to be transferred to the Culture Ministry. "The process is on. We don't know what will be the outcome," Choudhury says, adding it will be better as it is impossible to provide or preserve Tagore's legacy with only ugc funds. "The perception that secu-